ACTIVITY 12

Divide into groups. Look again at Emily's story in **5**. Each group should prepare to re-tell the story, using one or more subversions. Change the original version so that the narrative no longer follows the same path. The following suggestions may help you:

- Flashback – start the story from the moment when Emily is facing the dragon.
- Flashforward – begin the story with a dream sequence in which Emily faces a fire-breathing beast.
- Twist – Emily does not have to be human!
- Parallel narratives – tell Emily's story side by side with Prince Matthew's (or the dragon's) story. This could make the audience feel differently towards them.

Audience positioning



Audiences enjoy texts most when they are really involved in them. When you analyse a media text such as a film, identify the key techniques that 'sew' the audience into it. When they are genuinely hooked into the text's narrative and development, it is as if they actually have their own position in it. You can see why this is so important – someone who is really involved in a text is much less likely to switch it off or put it back on the shelf. Here are some techniques that help an audience to become involved or positioned in a film or television text.

- **Point-of-view shots** – the camera adopts the position of a character within the text. This can be an over-the-shoulder shot, looking at whatever the character is looking at, or a shot from the point of view of the character. This is particularly powerful when the character is experiencing a strong emotion – the viewer is more likely to feel their emotion when taking their point of view.
- **Reaction shots** – the camera moves to an extreme close-up of a character's face to show their reaction to something that has happened (see **6**: Eddie Murphy in *The Nutty Professor* (1996)).



6 Reading facial expression is crucial to understanding a character's reaction

- **Insert shots** – this technique gives the audience extra or privileged information that one or more characters may not yet know, for example in a two-set scene with two characters in different locations. The audience knows what is happening to each of them when the characters themselves do not.
- **Shot reverse shot** – the camera alternates between two characters to show their building relationship (whether positive or negative), often as a conversation is taking place between them. This is a very common technique in dramas where the inter-relationship between characters is very important. The camera acts as a third person in shot reverse shot, giving the audience the impression that they are turning their heads from one character to the other.



7 These three images demonstrate the shot reverse shot technique

ACTIVITY 13

1 Watch a series of film clips from different genres. Identify as many techniques of audience positioning as possible.

2 Using a still camera, create a series of shots which demonstrate each of the audience positioning techniques. Display them in your classroom with an imaginary narrative situation written underneath each one. You can see an example in **7**.

Additional camera terms and definitions



A great deal of time is spent on setting up every scene in a film. It is important to position the cameras in just the right way to capture on film exactly what the director wants the audience to see. In addition to the techniques mentioned already, here are some other camera shots that you will be able to identify in the films you study.

Camera term	What it means
Establishing shot	The camera is set far back to show or to emphasise setting or location rather than the subject
Slo-mo	A moment which is replayed very slowly
Pan shot	The camera moves horizontally, taking in all the details along the way
Tracking shot	The camera moves alongside characters either using a hand-held technique or smooth dolly tracks
Zoom	The camera focuses in on, or out from, a subject by using a telephoto lens
Mini cam	A tiny camera is placed in an unusual place for effect
Steadi-cam	A weighted camera is strapped to an operator to allow hand-held but controlled movement

TIP

Using a chart or table to present textual analysis will help you to keep under the word limit.

ACTIVITY 14 EXTENSION

Watch the first ten minutes of one of these films: *Star Wars IV: A New Hope* (1997), *The Truman Show* (1998) or *Saving Private Ryan* (1998). Look for evidence of genre characteristics, narrative structure, audience positioning and carefully set up camerawork. Present your findings as a table, chart, report or essay.

Intertextuality

Have you ever experienced the thrill of watching a film and recognising a reference to another film? This type of link between two texts is known as an **intertextual reference**. Do you recognise the phrases 'I'll be back' and 'shaken not stirred'? Where have you heard them? Can you think of other phrases which you have heard used intertextually in films or TV programmes?

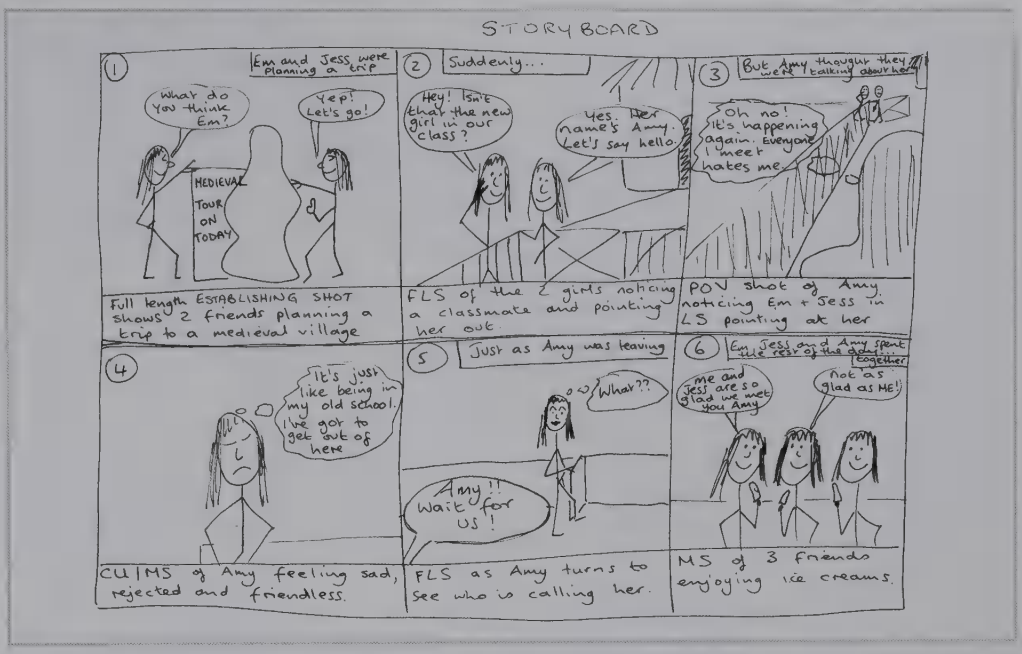
Intertextual references can be visual as well. You can find a good example of this in *Toy Story 2* (1999). The toys are riding around Al's Toy Barn in a Barbie Tour guide car and Rex the dinosaur is running behind them, his reflection clearly seen in the wing mirror. This is an intertextual reference to the scene in *Jurassic Park* (1993) when the T-Rex can be seen in the wing mirror chasing the tour guide vehicle – in this case, with the intention of eating the passengers!

Another example is the Robin Hood scene in *Shrek* (2000) when Princess Fiona fights Robin Hood and his men; she fights in the same style as Trinity from *The Matrix* (1999).

The story of *Bridget Jones Diary* (2001) is full of intertextual references to Jane Austin's *Pride and Prejudice*, although the settings and the characters of the heroines could hardly be more different. The basic storyline is similar: girl meets and hates boy but after many mishaps realises his true worth and marries him. Among other references,

KEY TERM

Intertextual reference when one media text mimics or refers to another media text in a way that many consumers will recognise



This student's completed storyboard for a photo-comic could be adapted to make a short film

Production

The production stage involves making the ideas on your storyboard into shots taken by a camera crew. You not have to shoot everything in exactly the same order as it comes on your storyboard, especially if it involves different locations. You can put things into the right order in the edit at the post-production stage.

Shot log

To save you time when you come to edit, it is a good idea always to keep a **shot log** (see the example in **3**). If you are using a sophisticated camera, you might be able to record the time code on the logging sheet, to give you an exact reference in seconds for each shot on the tape.

If, as is more likely, you are working with simpler equipment, you need to log how long the shot is and a *cumulative time*, that is, how many minutes of tape have been shot in all. This will help you find them more quickly when you come to edit. In this case it is a good idea to use a *clapper board*. All you need is a small blackboard and chalk, or a white board and marker pen. Every time you roll the camera, focus first on the clapper board on which you have written the exact shot number and take number.

TIP

If you can access *MediaStage* software, create a performance of your storyboard to refine your planning. A print out of your screen shots could be used as evidence.

KEY TERM

Shot log a list of all the shots you take in the order in which they occur on the source tape

Camera operator: JG
Camera: Canon XM 1

Location: Lydford
Date: 4th June 04

Shot no.	Set up: ELS/LS/MLS/MS/MCU/CU/ECU	Take Good (G) or No good (NG)?	Notes on shot content	Time code
1	ELS	NG	Tripod knocked	00: 31: 14
1	ELS	G	Shot down over the valley, showing village	00: 31: 27
2	LS	G	Tilt down church spire to door	00: 31: 46

Your shot log should look like this

Using thirds

Where will you place significant elements in your picture? Research has shown that viewers look first at the human face – especially the eyes – and any points of high contrast. Photographers often talk about the *principle of thirds*. When looking through the viewfinders of their cameras, they imagine a grid formed by two vertical and two horizontal lines which divide the picture into thirds. They then place key elements of the composition, often using a one-third to two-thirds proportion. Look at photograph **10** and think about the way it has used thirds for its composition.



10 This photo was composed using the principle of thirds

Lines of movement

Photographs are often thought to have a stronger composition if the objects in them are seen as 'moving into' the picture – see **11**.



11 The men are looking into the right of this frame

Diagonals and horizontals

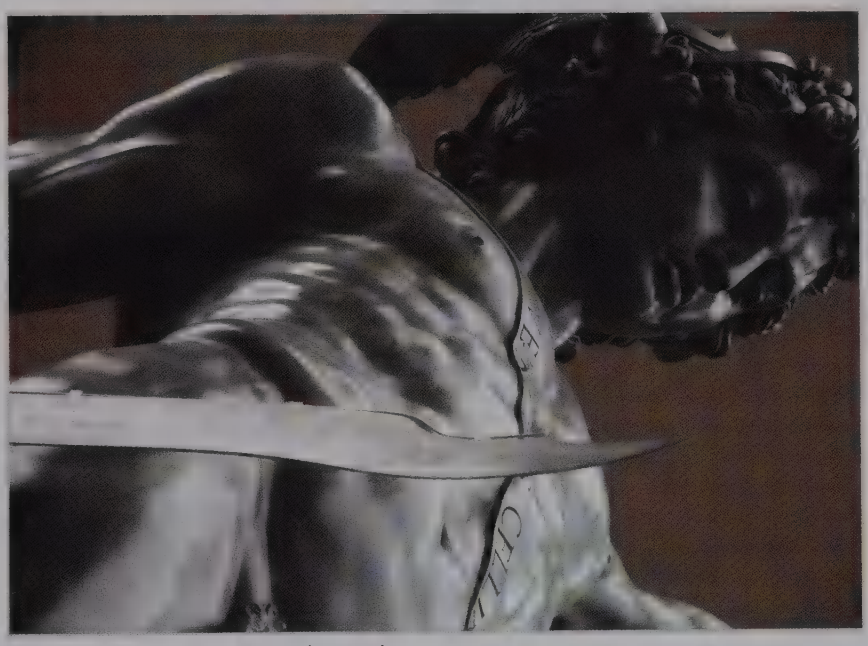
Diagonal lines in compositions are said to be more dynamic than horizontal ones. How have lines been used in the composition in image **12**?



12 St Marks Square, Venice

Angle

Most photographs are taken at eye level. Taking them from above or below, as in **13**, your subject can be another way of creating visual impact.



13 This photo was taken from a low angle

Light

Getting the lighting right can mean more than just making sure there is enough light. The factors mentioned for video production on page 175 apply equally to lighting for a still photograph. Strong sunlight coming through the overhead railway in Brooklyn adds to the composition of photograph **14**.